

DecisionBrief — Conversation Transcript

Scenario: general • Dental Clinic • 8 Operatories • Aging iTero Element 1 (2018) • 45 Scans/Day • Replace vs Repair

2026-05-14 05:01 PM

DecisionBrief: Tell me about your situation — what decision are you actually trying to make?

You: I own a 8-operator dental clinic in Austin — 4 dentists, 4 hygienists, 12 staff total, \$2.8M annual revenue, about 45 scans a day. We have a 2018 iTero Element 1 3D scanner — 6 years old, out of warranty since 2021. Last month it died mid-procedure twice — 3 days downtime each time, \$4,500 repair quoted, images are blurry on molars leading to 12% remake rate for crowns. We have an Invisalign partnership starting Sept 1 that requires <3 min scans and 5D caries detection. Decision is whether to replace now, repair for \$4,500 and keep, or switch to new vendor.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — 8 ops, 4 dentists, 45 scans/day, 2018 iTero Element 1, 6 years old, 2 failures last month 3 days downtime each, \$4,500 repair, 12% remake rate, Invisalign partnership Sept 1 needs <3 min and 5D. What's your current approach?

You: Current is iTero Element 1 plus backup alginate impressions when scanner down — we had to reschedule 18 patients last month and borrowed scanner from neighboring clinic twice. Integration is with Dentrix G7 and iTero lab portal. Dentists say scan takes 8 minutes now vs 4 minutes when new, staff hates calibration that takes 45 minutes. We also have CBCT but not integrated. No backup scanner owned. Front desk loses \$3k revenue per downtime day from rescheduling.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — backup alginate, 18 patients rescheduled last month, borrowed twice, Dentrix G7 + iTero lab portal, 8 min scans now vs 4 min new, 45-min calibration, CBCT not integrated, no owned backup, \$3k revenue loss per downtime day. What triggered this now?

You: Three triggers — \$4,500 repair quote last week with only 90-day warranty on fix, Align Technology said our Element 1 won't be supported after Dec 31 2026 and new Invisalign cases need 5D Plus for caries detection to qualify for partnership tier that gives us \$15k/year in marketing funds, and remake rate jumped from 4% to 12% in last 3 months causing lab fees \$2,200 extra and patient complaints 5 cases. Also hygienist threatened to quit because scanning is slow.

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DecisionBrief: Clear — \$4,500 repair 90-day warranty, support ends Dec 31 2026, Invisalign partnership needs 5D Plus for \$15k/yr marketing funds, remake 4% to 12% \$2,200 extra lab fees 5 complaints, hygienist quit risk. What options have you looked at?

You: Looked at iTero Element 5D Plus \$35k, Primescan from Dentsply Sirona \$28k, Medit i700 Wireless \$22k, and 3Shape Trios 5 \$32k. iTero 5D Plus integrates with existing Invisalign workflow but \$35k plus \$3k/year service. Primescan faster 2-min scans but needs new lab integration — our lab charges \$150 extra per case if not iTero. Medit \$22k cheap and wireless but no 5D caries detection for Invisalign partnership \$15k funds. Trios 5 \$32k good but Dentrix integration is clunky per forum. Also considered repairing \$4,500 and keeping Element 1 as backup if we buy new.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — Element 5D Plus \$35k + \$3k/yr service, Primescan \$28k + \$150/case lab fee if not iTero, Medit i700 \$22k wireless no 5D for \$15k funds, Trios 5 \$32k Dentrix clunky, repair \$4,500 as backup idea. What matters most to you?

You: Accuracy first — need <2% remake rate vs 12% now, speed <3 min vs 8 min now to handle 45 scans/day and Invisalign Sept 1 deadline, integration with Dentrrix G7 and lab without \$150 extra per case, ease for hygienists — wireless preferred, 5D caries detection to get \$15k/year marketing funds from Align, uptime — can't have 3 days downtime \$3k loss per day, and financing not \$35k cash upfront. Also patient comfort — Element 1 is bulky kids gag.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — accuracy <2% vs 12%, speed <3 min vs 8 min for 45 scans/day and Sept 1, Dentrrix G7 + lab no \$150 extra, wireless ease for hygienists, 5D for \$15k/yr funds, uptime avoiding \$3k/day loss, financing not cash. patient comfort kids gag. What constraints and budget?

You: Budget \$35k hard cap \$50k if perfect including service and training, can't do \$35k cash — need 0% financing 24 months or lease \$800/mo max. Must be live by Aug 15 before Sept 1 Invisalign partnership. Need trade-in for Element 1 — dealer offered \$2k only. Need training for 4 dentists + 4 hygienists included not \$2k extra. Operatory space is tight — Element 1 cart is large. Need service response <24hrs not 3 days. Also need to keep Dentrrix G7 — can't switch practice management.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — \$35k cap \$50k perfect incl service training, 0% 24mo or lease \$800/mo max not \$35k cash, live by Aug 15 before Sept 1, trade-in \$2k offered, training 8 staff included not \$2k extra, tight operatory cart size, service <24hrs not 3 days. must keep Dentrrix G7. Any prior experience with these vendors?

You: iTero experience — Element 1 from 2018, support ended 2021, repair \$4,500 now 90-day warranty, calibration 45 min pain, but Invisalign workflow familiar and lab likes iTero — no \$150 extra. No experience with Primescan — dentist friend said Primescan accurate but Dentsply support slow 48hrs and lab \$150 extra per case adds \$6k/year for 40 cases/month. Medit — tried at conference wireless nice but no 5D and integration with Dentrrix needed workaround. 3Shape — heard Trios 5 wireless great but Dentrrix integration clunky and \$3k/year service. Prior bad experience with scanner salesman overpromising speed.

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DecisionBrief: Clear — iTero familiar no \$150 extra lab but support ended 2021 repair \$4,500 90-day 45-min calibration, Primescan accurate but support 48hrs and \$150/case = \$6k/yr for 40 cases/mo, Medit wireless but no 5D Dentrrix workaround, Trios 5 wireless but Dentrrix clunky \$3k/yr service, salesman overpromising past. What risks worry you?

You: Buying \$35k Element 5D Plus and still having 12% remake rate because accuracy not fixed — \$2,200 extra lab fees continues, buying Medit \$22k and losing \$15k/yr marketing funds because no 5D for Invisalign tier, buying Primescan \$28k and paying \$150/case extra = \$6k/year = \$30k over 5 years plus lab resists, integration failing with Dentrrix G7 causing front desk double entry and \$3k/day downtime, hygienists refusing to use because bulky or calibration 45 min and quitting, financing \$35k cash upfront not possible lease \$800/mo max, and repairing \$4,500 with 90-day warranty and support ends Dec 31 2026 then dead again.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — \$35k not fixing 12% remake \$2,200 extra, \$22k losing \$15k/yr funds no 5D, \$28k + \$150/case = \$6k/yr \$30k over 5 yrs lab resistance, Dentrrix G7 integration fail double entry \$3k/day loss, hygienist refusal 45-min calibration quit risk, \$35k cash impossible lease \$800/mo max, \$4,500 repair 90-day support ends Dec 31 2026. Who else is affected and what does success look like?

You: Affected — 4 dentists who need speed <3 min and accuracy <2% remake, 4 hygienists who need wireless and easy calibration not 45 min and threaten quit, 12 staff front desk who rescheduled 18 patients last month losing \$3k/day, patients — 5 complaints last month gagging kids, lab who charges \$150 extra if not iTero, Align partnership for \$15k/yr funds needs 5D by Sept 1, and me owner \$2.8M revenue. Success in 12 months: scan <3 min vs 8 min now, remake <2% vs 12% now, no downtime 3 days — service <24hrs, 45 scans/day handled without borrowing or alginate, hygienists using daily no complaints, patient comfort kids no gag, Dentrrix G7

integration no double entry, lab no \$150 extra, Invisalign partnership live Sept 1 getting \$15k/yr marketing funds, total under \$35k cap \$50k perfect with financing \$800/mo max or 0% 24mo, training included for 8 staff, and old Element 1 kept as backup or traded for \$2k.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — 4 dentists <3 min <2% remake, 4 hygienists wireless easy not 45 min quit risk, front desk 18 rescheduled \$3k/day loss, patients 5 complaints kids gag, lab \$150 extra, Align \$15k/yr needs 5D by Sept 1, owner \$2.8M. What would you do if you couldn't replace?

You: If can't replace, repair Element 1 for \$4,500 with 90-day warranty and keep using alginate backup when it dies — reschedule 18 patients a month, lose \$3k/day, keep 12% remake \$2,200 extra lab fees, risk support ends Dec 31 2026 and no Invisalign partnership \$15k/yr funds, hygienist may quit, but avoid \$35k spend and financing. Would also consider used Element 2 for \$15k but same support risk. Really don't want repair — want new with wireless and 5D and <3 min and financing \$800/mo max.

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DecisionBrief: I have enough information to prepare your Decision Brief.